CURRENT AFFAIRS

DIWALI NEEDS NO TRANSLATION, MR KHARGE

By **Kamlesh Bhagatkar**, *Author & Geopolitical Analyst · 10 November 2026*

On 7 November, while giving Diwali greetings to reporters, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge described the festival with a phrase that has now become a national row. According to Organiser, his words were "Diwali, khushiyon ka Eid hai." ANI, as carried by Asianet News, rendered the remark in English as "Many people celebrate it as it is an Eid of Happiness."

The rest of his message was a normal festival greeting. Kharge said, "I extend my best wishes to everyone for Diwali," and appealed for peace: "I urge those who may be in conflict or harbouring misunderstandings with one another to set these differences aside." I quote him in full because fairness demands it. But one phrase is what people heard, and the Congress president should have known they would.

By Sunday and Monday, BJP leaders had made the remark their main line of attack. BJP spokesperson Gaurav Bhatia called Kharge a "remote-controlled national president of Congress" and accused the party of an "anti-Hindu, anti-Sanatan mindset". Union Minister Giriraj Singh told ANI, "Kharge is a mouthpiece of Rahul Gandhi and the Gandhi family." Madhya Pradesh minister Vishvas Sarang said, "It is shameful that he refers to Diwali as Eid." BJP spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari wrote on X: "Congress is Anti-Sanatan!"

How Congress answered

A simple sentence from Kharge could have ended this: "I meant only that Diwali is a festival of joy, and I am sorry if anyone was hurt." It never came. Congress chose to attack instead.

Congress MP Pawan Khera said "Eid" simply means "tyohar", a festival, and that it could apply to Diwali and Holi as well. Then he asked, "Does anybody in the BJP have a dictionary in their house?" and called BJP leaders "illiterate, ignorant fools." NCP-SP spokesperson Clyde Crasto said, "India is a secular country," and told the BJP to "stop politicising religion."

Look at who else was uneasy. Union Minister Ramdas Athawale said it is "not appropriate to bring Hindus and Muslims into this context." Organiser reported that AIMIM spokesperson Waris Pathan also criticised the comparison, arguing that Diwali and Eid are different festivals. When even an

AIMIM spokesperson finds the comparison odd, I do not think the problem lies only in the BJP's reading.

Why the words matter

I want to be careful here. Eid is a festival of joy for crores of our Muslim fellow citizens, and it deserves the same respect as any other. Nothing in this row should become a quarrel between communities. My criticism is of a political party and its leadership, not of any faith.

But Diwali needs no translation. It is the festival of lights, of Lakshmi puja and of Ram's return to Ayodhya, and every Indian child knows its meaning. Explaining it through the name of another festival, as if Indians needed help understanding it, says more about the speaker's frame of mind than about Diwali. Even if Kharge meant no harm, the president of a national party should choose such words with care.

I think the real damage comes from the pattern, as many Hindus see it. Organiser listed earlier episodes: in October 2024, the Congress government in Karnataka limited firecrackers on Diwali to 8 pm to 10 pm and allowed only green crackers, which the government said it did on environmental and legal grounds, and which BJP leaders called a curb on Hindu celebration. In October 2025, Congress leader Rashid Alvi questioned the Uttar Pradesh government's spending on Diwali decorations. Each of these had its own explanation. Put together, they leave many voters with the sense that Congress is uneasy with Hindu festivals in a way it is not with others.

I think that impression has hurt Congress with voters, and Khera's reply will only deepen it. Calling your critics "illiterate, ignorant fools" for being hurt by a remark about their festival does not win them back. It tells them they were right.

Where the BJP stands

As I understand it, the BJP's argument is that India's cultural identity and its secular constitution sit comfortably together, and that respect for the majority's faith does not mean disrespect for anyone else's. In my view, this row shows why that argument keeps finding listeners. A party that wishes Hindus on Diwali without hedging, and Muslims on Eid without hedging, needs no dictionary to explain itself.

Not every BJP attack was measured. Bhatia's claim that Congress has an "anti-Hindu" mindset is a political charge, and readers can judge it for themselves. But the basic question the BJP asked, why the Congress president could not simply call Diwali by its own name, has still not been answered.

What to watch next

The first thing to watch is whether Kharge himself clarifies or expresses regret, or leaves the defence to Khera and his allies. The second is whether other INDI Alliance partners distance themselves from the remark. Holi is the next big festival on the calendar, and it will show whether Congress has taken anything from this week.

Sources

- Asianet News (ANI): BJP-Congress clash erupts over Kharge's 'Eid of happiness' remark
- Organiser: From 'khushiyon ki Eid' to Babri tears, BJP calls Congress anti-Sanatan



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